

THE WORLD'S FIRST POWERED FLIGHT

WAITING EXPECTANTLY

The Wright's Flyer sits outside the makeshift hangar at their Kill Devil Hills camp (left). Below, the brothers' ground crew and audience are pictured next to the Flyer, which has been transferred to its wooden rail just before Wilbur's flight of December 14, 1903.

trolley running along a wooden rail. Wilbur and Orville stood by the machine while the engine warmed up. Then, as one of the lifesavers, John Daniels, later recounted, "they shook hands, and we couldn't help notice how they held on to each other's hand... like two folks parting who weren't sure they'd ever see each other again."

A camera had been positioned to capture the scene and Daniels was entrusted with operating the shutter. Orville mounted the machine, lying face down. Then, amid the racket of the engine and excited shouts from the onlookers, the machine was released from its restraining rope and set off along the track. As it lifted into

the air, Daniels took the picture below.

Like his brother three days earlier, Orville found it hard to control the Flyer, and after 12 seconds in the air, he came down with a bump. Whether this or two subsequent attempts constituted true powered flights was rendered irrelevant by the fourth attempt. Orville, this time an onlooker, described what happened in his diary: "At just 12 o'clock Will started on the fourth and last trip. The machine started off with its ups and downs as it had before, but by the time he had gone over three or four hundred feet he had it under much better control,

ON THE MORNING OF DECEMBER 17, 1903, the wind at Kill Devil Hills was gusting at up to 30mph (48kph). This would help the Wright Flyer get off the ground, but was sure to create problems in controlling the untested machine. Although Wilbur Wright's first brief hop into the air with the Flyer three days earlier had ended swiftly and ingloriously, the Wrights were certain their powered machine could fly.

The brothers had agreed to alternate at the controls, so it was Orville's turn first on this occasion. At 10:00am a flag was run up to signal to the helpful personnel of the nearby Kill Devil Hills lifesaving station, who had agreed to act as witnesses and helpers. The brothers then set about laying a wooden launch track alongside their campsite. The Flyer was too heavy to be launched like a glider – by two men holding the wings – and wheels would have sunk into the soft sand. So the machine was to be launched from a



"It was only a flight of 12 seconds, and it was an uncertain, wavy, creeping sort of flight... but it was a real flight at last and not a glide."

ORVILLE WRIGHT

ON THE FIRST POWERED HEAVIER-THAN-AIR FLIGHT

AN HISTORIC IMAGE

On December 17, 1903, the Wright Flyer lifted off the sands in the first-ever manned flight. Orville was at the controls and Wilbur, caught midstride, watches in amazement. This photograph, taken by John Daniels, became one of the most reproduced images of the 20th century.

